Pattern of Disempowerment

Robertsganj is typical of how a cussed pattern of disempowerment, with social and political factors combining, defeats the very purpose of electoral reservation in these seats. The Chamars (called Jatavs in more western parts), at 225,000, are by far the biggest component of the 22.67 per cent Dalit population here. But, incredibly, they have not seen a single MP from among them since 1989—in nine elections. By contrast, the Kols, a small demographic pool of 75,000-80,000, have seen four electoral triumphs here. They simply fit better into the calculus of parties. Even the Kharwars, only the SC component of whose 100,000 population can contest, had an MP in 2014.

A close-up analysis of Robertsganj reveals how exactly this subversion plays out. First, the broad rules. The population ratio of Dalits in a state determines the number of seats it has to reserve for the SCs, and such constituencies are chosen where, "so far as practicable, the percentage of the (SC) population to the total is the largest, in descending order". But Dalits, by the very nature of society, are distributed evenly across the land—unlike Adivasis. "You rarely find an SC reserved seat where the Dalit population is over 30 per cent," says psephologist and activist Yogendra Yadav. Dalits and Adivasis make up nearly 40 per cent of Robertsganj, but a 'coalition of the oppressed' is not how things work. Axiomatically, therefore, non-Dalits form an overwhelming majority in all SC reserved seats across states. So, guess whose opinion counts?

An Ethnic Melting Pot

Yadukul Milk Products. The tidy shop seemed like a reasonable place to duck in from the May heat outside—and sample the 'Yadav mood'. It should have been a cinch. Behind the smiling, square-set face and piercing eyes of Saurabh Yadav, the 25-year-old owner, there were clearly as many opinions brewing as there were bottles and polystyrene cups stacked behind the counter. But the narrow space within fills up too soon. It's an ethnic smorgasbord you'd think unusual for mofussil UP, some with atypical traits to boot.

A Gond tailor from the next shop who wants to talk about *adhyatma* (the Hindu spiritual concept of the universal self), a Jha whose priestly duty at the local Kali temple ticks the tantric side of ritual worship, a Kharwar with a small unit that makes styrofoam plates and cups for weddings, a Vishwakarma who works in the electricity department, and another Yadav—a dapper with a Ramnaami bandanna and a dhaba at the end of the street. Even the unforced flow of conversation drifts towards the elections and the ensemble of related themes: Ayodhya, jobs and the perceived threat to the Constitution, which is apparently "all over town but has only partially penetrated the interiors".

A line spoken at the Chakia shop cuts to the chase: "*Kharwar lad jaaye, Gond lad jaaye, Kol lad jaaye...bas Chamar se darte hain. Unki aakrosh waali maansikta hai* (let anyone contest, a Kharwar, a Gond, a Kol...but we only fear a Chamar/Jatav. They act in anger)." Especially when the non-Dalits often include a big quantum of dominant castes who, as Yadav says, "naturally don't like assertive Dalits". That's a bit of a throwaway line: some of



A DIFFERENT RHYTHM
A Gond wedding at Babbandiha village. The Gonds are among the Adivasi groups that comprise 17 per cent of the Robertsganj LS constituency